

A screenshot of a terminal window during Linux installation. It features a shield icon with a star inside. To the right of the icon, the text reads: "The root account is used for administering the system. Enter a password for the root user." Below this, there are two input fields. The first is labeled "Root Password:" and the second is labeled "Confirm:". Both fields are empty and have a light gray background with a thin black border.

During install you will need to supply a root password

If you are familiar with the Windows Administrator idea, you will know that tasks such as the formatting of disks or burning of CDs are accessible only to the Administrator. The root is something like that in Linux, but a lot more powerful.

Amongst others, one privilege of the root user is the ability to grant or revoke permissions to other users. A user can be given limited root privileges by the root user, for example, in a network, where the root user is on leave and an assistant has to take care of basic maintenance.

The root concept is something native to UNIX-like systems, including Linux. The term “root” springs from the file structure of UNIX, in which all directories branch off from a single directory called “root.”

In Linux itself, the root user or admin must not be confused with the root directory, denoted by a forward slash (/), which is the directory that contains all other directories (system and user directories). There is also a */root* directory under the (/). This is the home directory of the root user. The home directories for other users are under a directory called */home*.

The idea of not allowing all users to make system modifications is a derivative of the days of legacy networks, where users would be connected to a mainframe though a terminal. (The concept of PC did not exist in the early days of UNIX.) Thus, each user would need to have access to his own files, but not be able to change system set-